

Topic: Social mobility and social inequality

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Social mobility

- Social mobility refers to the shift in an individual's social status from one status to another. The shift can either be higher, lower, inter-generational, or intra-generational, and it cannot necessarily be determined if the change is for good or bad.
- Dressler (1969), “ Social mobility is the movement of individuals from one stratum to another.”
- “ Social mobility refers to the movement of individuals between different levels of social hierarchy, usually defined in terms of broad occupational and social class categories” (The Penguin Dictionary of Sociology, 1984).

Types of social mobility

1. Horizontal social mobility: It is a change in position without the change in status. It indicates a change in position within the range of same status.

2. Vertical mobility

- This refers to a change in the occupational, political, or religious status of a person that causes a change in their societal position. An individual moves from one social stratum to another. Vertical mobility can be ascending/ upward or descending/ downward.
- Ascending involves an individual moving from a group in a lower stratum to a higher one. Descending mobility occurs, for example, when a businessman incurs losses in his business and is forced to declare [bankruptcy](#), resulting in a move to a lower stratum of society.

Types of social mobility (continue)

3. Inter-generational mobility

- Inter-generational mobility happens when the social position changes from one generation to another.

4. Intra-generational mobility

- The intra-generational change in societal position occurs during the lifespan of a single generation. It can also refer to a change in position between siblings.

Consequences of Social Mobility

- ❖ Economic consequences
- ❖ Social consequences
- ❖ Psychological consequences
- ❖ Political consequences
- ❖ Inter-generational and intra-generational consequences

Definition of Social Inequality

- ❖ **Social inequality** is the existence of unequal opportunities and rewards for different social positions or statuses within a group or society.
- ❖ “ Social inequality exists when some people have greater share of power, wealth or prestige than others” (Robertson, 1980:213).
- ❖ Dahrendorf (1959:61) said that social inequality means“ Disparities of wealth, prestige or power and authority”

Determinants of social inequality

1. Biological factors and social inequality

- Social inequality by sex
- Social inequality by age
- Intellectual differentiation
- Race and social inequality
- Physical fitness
- Appearance

Determinants of social inequality (continue)

2. Social factors and Social inequality

- Division of labor and social inequality
- Social inequality by caste
- Social inequality by class
- Social inequality by power
- Membership in voluntary association and social inequality
- Social inequality due to differential social role
- Demand and supply
- Social-psychological factor

Dimensions of social inequality

1. Inequality of wealth, income and consumption
2. Inequality in health and longevity
3. Inequality in freedom, self-determination and justice
4. Inequality in the distribution of services
5. Inequality in community participation, influence and power

Other dimensions-

- Inequality in occupation
- Inequality in education
- Inequality in gender.